However, the Jammu and Kashmir Police had no idea that Zahgir was involved in either the Red Kashmir posters or the Nawakadal murder.

In April 1968, Zahgir was once again released from prison without the police linking him to the two crimes. In July 1968, Zahgir, along with Nazir Ahmed Wani, travelled across the Ramgarh-Sialkot border into Pakistan. The two met a Pakistani IB official, who identified himself as Zafar Iqbal Rathore; Rathore was to become their case officer. They also met a Maj. Tufail and Col. Bashir. Zahgir and Wani were instructed to send small groups of men for military training and were themselves to return again for a longer period of specialised training. Shortly after Zahgir's return from Pakistan, two new recruits joined him. They were Mohammad Aslam Wani and Zahoor Ahmad Shahdad. The two planned to rob rifles from an armoury used to store rifles for the National Cadet Corps, situated at the Islamia College. The robbery was a failure and one of the groups of robbers that was caught on the spot led the police to Wani and Shahdad. Once the dots had been joined, the trail revealed the role of Zahgir. He swiftly fled to Pakistan in November 1968. Over there, he was trained by the Pakistan Army field intelligence unit in all the skills he would require to wage a guerrilla war against the Indian state.

Master Cell's Transformation into Al-Fatah

As early as 1968, during the waning years of Ayub Khan's presidency, Pakistan's greater strategic imperatives were being integrated with the planning and execution of a widespread covert war with India. Zahgir became the nucleus of this effort. He had developed a map that would not just cause the defeat of the Indian security forces but would also bring down its entire apparatus of power and control. In this visionary plan, tax strikes, protests by the unemployed and demands by bureaucrats for higher pay—all had a role in the larger political struggle against India. Zahgir now chose the name Al-Fatah for his organisation. In Arabic as in Urdu, the name means liberation, salvation and conquest. The initiation of this major plan to subvert India through the starting point of Jammu and Kashmir predates the